



EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

Managing Conflict

Managing Conflict

22%

of participants experience challenges with managing conflict.
Of those, 82% also have challenges with Procrastination and
73% with 'Focusing on things they can control'

90%

Managing Conflict is a strength for 90% of people with **high levels** of resilience

74%

Managing Conflict is a strength for 74% of people with **average levels** of resilience

47%

Managing Conflict is a strength for 47% of people with **low levels** of resilience



Managing Conflict

- Why do people avoid conflict in the work environment?
- What are the common reasons for workplace conflict?
- What is the impact of avoiding conflict?
- Think of an example that happened to you, what was the situation, what happened and what was the outcome?

Why do people avoid conflict?

- Fear of upsetting others
- Expecting a negative outcome
- Lack of self-confidence

What are common reasons for workplace conflict?

- Misunderstandings / Poor communication
- Differing viewpoints, opinions, personalities
- Competing priorities and demands on time and resources

What is the impact of avoiding conflict?

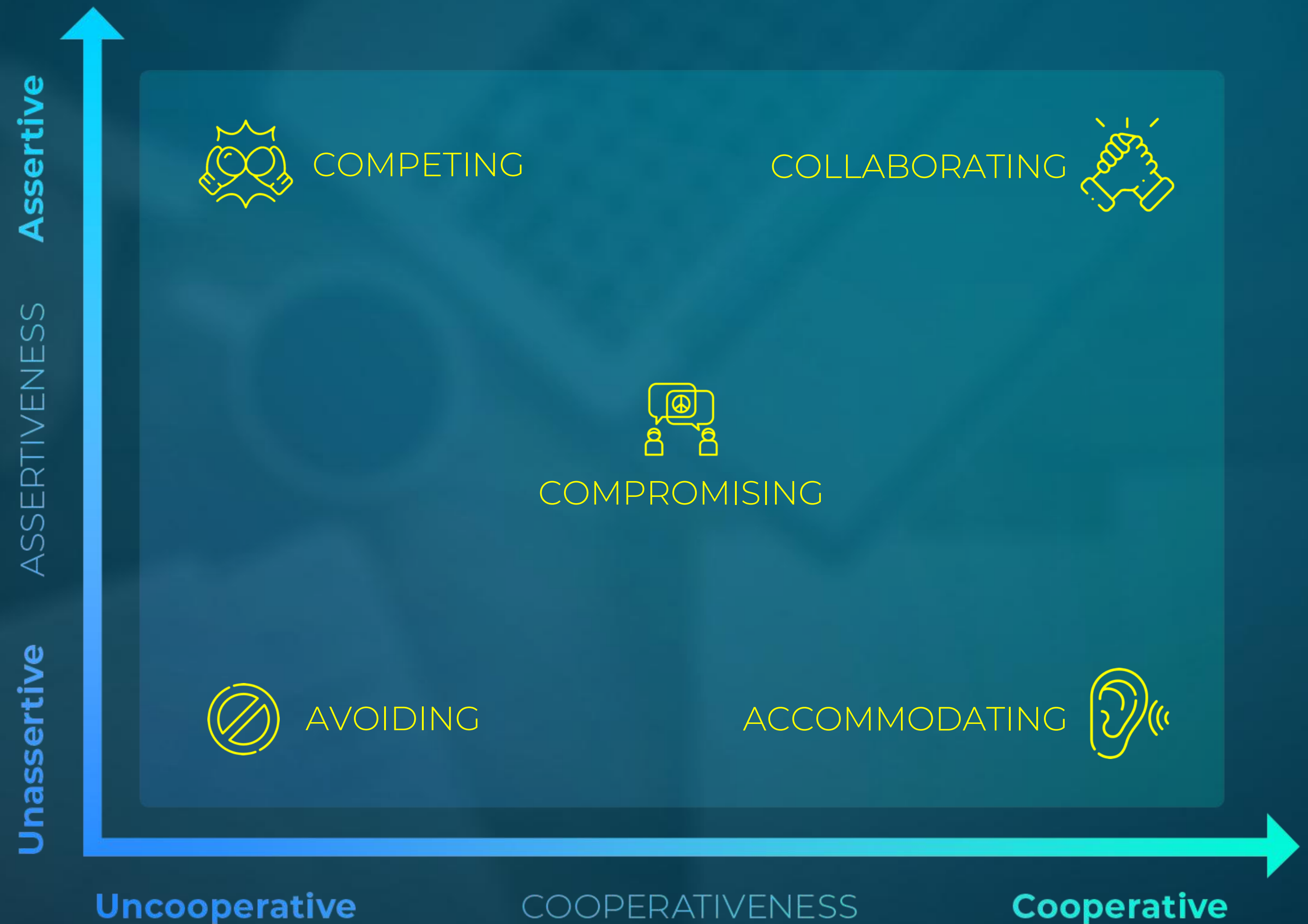
- Situation may become much worse if unresolved, even toxic
- Creates frustration and bottles up emotions
- Can impact physical and mental health and self-esteem
- Damages the work environment, lowers morale and motivation
- Reduced productivity, missed deadlines, customer dissatisfaction

Five Methods of Managing Conflict

In a conflict situation you have 2 basic decisions to make:

- How assertive to be
- How co-operative to be

There are then 5 conflict resolution styles to choose from depending on the situation.



Thomas & Kilmann 1974

Conflict Resolution – Styles & Tips

	WHEN TO USE	BEST PRACTICE	RISK
 COMPETING	When you want to 'win.' When you know you are right. Things you are passionate about.	Express your needs clearly & confidently but not aggressively. Avoid emotive language. Highlight benefits to the individual. Be gracious in victory.	Can come across as authoritative and dictatorial. Can cause bad feeling. Can damage relationships.
 ACCOMMODATING	When you are happy for the other person to have their way. When the issue isn't important to you. When the relationship is more important.	Point out that even though it may not be your preference, you are willing to agree, in the interests of the relationship. Show that you are thinking of the 'bigger picture.'	Danger that you may be seen as a 'pushover.' Danger that it may set a precedent.
 AVOIDING	Only use when the matter is totally trivial. Where there is no possible resolution. Where it makes sense for someone else to resolve the issue. Where the issue is likely to resolve itself.	Avoid for the right reasons (not because you want to avoid confronting the issue). Come to terms with it quickly.	Unresolved conflict can become toxic, so make 100% sure that you are avoiding for the right reasons.
 COLLABORATING	Appropriate for the resolution of important issues. Enables both parties to get a result they are happy with – 'win/win.'	Define your desired outcome in advance. Express your desire to resolve the issue. Understand their perspective and listen. Present your position. Discuss options & agree a way forward together.	Can be time consuming. Can be wearing for others.
 COMPROMISING	Appropriate for less important issues or where a quick answer is required. Both parties get some of what they want by establishing a 'middle ground.'	Requires good negotiation skills. Set expectations up front so all parties understand they won't be totally satisfied. Accept that it won't be perfect. Try to get the best possible outcome.	Potential risk that neither party walks away feeling satisfied with the outcome.

BEST PRACTICE

Conflict Resolution

Tips to managing conflict in the workplace include:



Assess the situation and address it if it's important rather than letting it go unresolved.



Consider how the other person might view the conflict, to help you have a more productive and empathetic discussion.



Find the right time and place, such as a safe space where you have time to talk about your differences at length in private.



Have a game plan going into the discussion, including the style you plan to adopt and what an acceptable solution looks like.



Communicate clearly and calmly, maintain positive eye and body language and emphasise your shared goals.



Listen attentively, ask questions, so you fully understand your colleague's perspective.

Conflict resolution skills to develop

- Active listening, non-verbal cues, and emotional intelligence.
- Eye contact and open body language.
- Calm and clear communication.
- Limit ego– acknowledge any miscommunication and mistakes.

Key Considerations

- Importance of the Issue.
- Importance of the relationship.
- Time constraints.
- Ultimate responsibility.

EXERCISE 1

Which Conflict Resolution Style?

1

You are working with a colleague who is passionate about a topic that isn't important to you. They want you to agree to a change in approach, which whilst not your preference, is workable.

2

You are working on a project and a legal issue arises which relates to employment law and the rights of employees. You are 100% certain that what your colleague is proposing is neither morally nor legally correct.

3

You are upset that you haven't been invited to attend the annual customer golf day. You could complain to the sales leader and see if you can change their mind.

4

You are defining a new service for your client with a colleague and you both have some very strong views on what should be included. The budget won't allow for everything, it's just not possible.

5

The launch of a new product is 2 months away and you need to agree on a plan with the product team. You both have some great ideas as to how to approach it and there are several options on the table.

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Which Conflict Resolution Style?

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ACCOMMODATING

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COMPETING

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AVOIDING

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COMPROMISING

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The launch of a new product is 2 months away and you need to agree on a plan with the product team. You both have some great ideas as to how to approach it and there are several options on the table.



COLLABORATING

Managing Conflict



EXERCISE 2 Conflict Resolution Analysis

Use the template to analyse a recent conflict you experienced. Document the conflict resolution style you used and the outcome.

Reflect on whether you would choose a different conflict resolution style if faced with the same situation again. If so, describe the style you believe would lead to a better outcome.

Describe the issue / conflict	My manager disagrees with my proposed recommendation for a customer system specification.		
Issue Importance (High/Medium/Low)	High	Time Constraints	Deadline in 5 working days
Relationship Importance (High/Medium/Low)	High	Ultimate responsibility	My manager
Conflict resolution style previously adopted & reasoning	Avoiding – I decided not to address the disagreement directly with my manager due to the limited time available and the high stakes involved. I focused on completing the tasks within my manager’s preferred approach to avoid potential conflict.		
Previous outcome	The issue was temporarily resolved, as the project moved forward based on my manager’s decision. However, the lack of discussion meant that some important aspects of my recommendation were overlooked, which caused inefficiencies later in the implementation phase.		
Conflict resolution style you would now adopt & detailed approach	Collaborative - set aside 30-60 mins to talk through the evidence that supports my recommendation (provide data analysis, output modelling), adopt an open mind and listen to the manager’s rationale, problem solve together to get a solution we both agree on and feel comfortable with, acknowledge my manager has ultimate responsibility for the outcome.		
Likely outcome	The most likely outcome is a well-researched and reasoned customer recommendation, using the experience of all parties.		